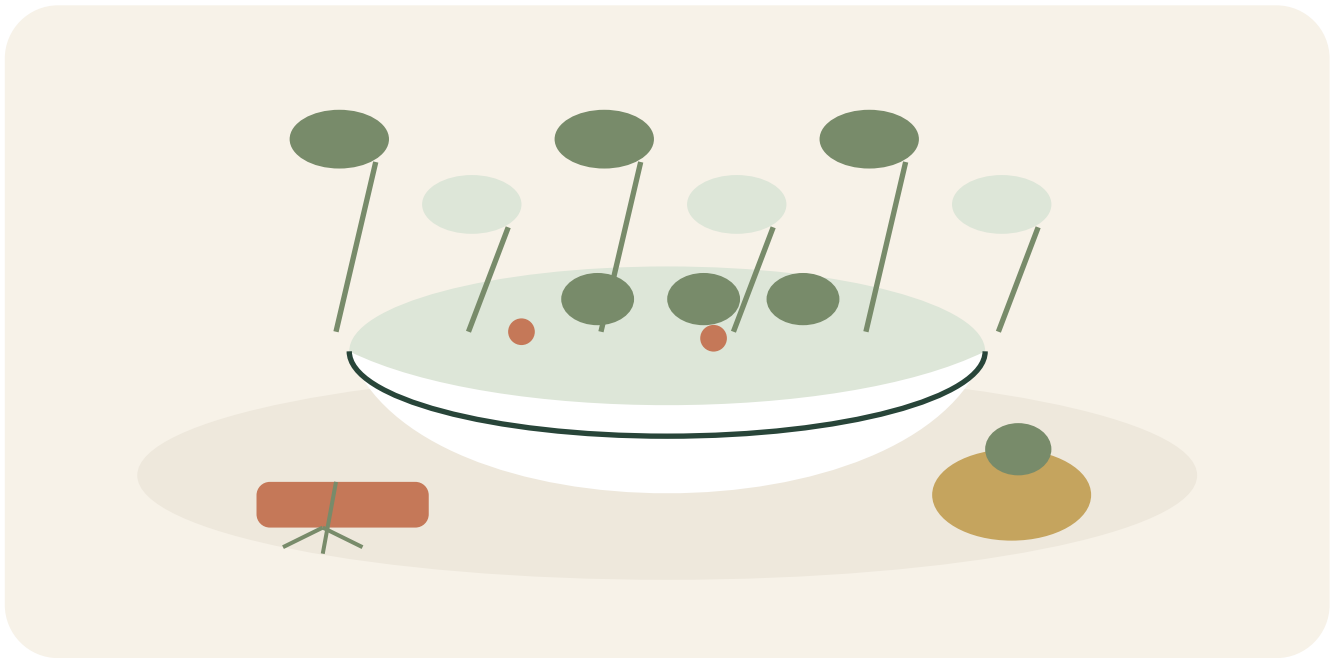


THE ROOT AND BOWL

50 Traditional Recipes for Everyday Digestive Comfort

A practical kitchen guide for adults 55+



FAMILIAR INGREDIENTS / WARM MEALS / THOUGHTFUL CHOICES

Food ideas for the table, with clear notes on personal choice and safety.

Inside this book

A quick route to the 50 recipes and kitchen companion pages.

CHAPTER 01

Warm bowls and familiar breakfasts

- 01 Ginger and Scallion Chicken Congee
- 02 Soft Oatmeal with Stewed Pear
- 03 Savory Oats with Egg and Spinach
- 04 Millet Porridge with Warm Apple
- 05 Steamed Egg Custard with Rice
- 06 Salmon and Rice Breakfast Bowl
- 07 Silken Tofu and Rice Bowl
- 08 Pumpkin Oatmeal with Cinnamon
- 09 Soft Polenta with a Fully Cooked Egg
- 10 Banana Oat Pancakes

CHAPTER 02

Simple soups and soft suppers

- 11 Carrot and Ginger Soup
- 12 Chicken, Rice, and Spinach Soup
- 13 Potato and Leek Soup
- 14 Red Lentil and Carrot Soup
- 15 Salmon and Potato Chowder
- 16 Silken Tofu and Mushroom Soup
- 17 Butternut Squash and White Bean Soup
- 18 Barley, Carrot, and Herb Soup
- 19 Egg-Drop Soup with Soft Greens
- 20 Soft Baked Potato with Yogurt and Chives

CHAPTER 03

Plant-forward comfort dishes

- 21 Savory Chickpea Flour Pancakes with Zucchini
- 22 Soft-Cooked Lentils with Carrots and Herbs
- 23 Brown Rice and Roasted Squash Bowl
- 24 Creamy White Beans on Whole-Grain Toast
- 25 Mashed Sweet Potato with Yogurt-Tahini Swirl
- 26 Baked Eggplant with White Beans and Herbs
- 27 Chickpea, Rice, and Soft Zucchini Bowl
- 28 Black Bean and Sweet Potato Mash
- 29 Quinoa, Spinach, and Egg Bowl
- 30 Buckwheat and Mushroom Pilaf

CHAPTER 04

East Asian-inspired home cooking

- 31 Mushroom and Scallion Rice Porridge
- 32 Tofu and Napa Cabbage Skillet
- 33 Sesame Rice Noodles with Tender Vegetables
- 34 Mild Miso Vegetable Soup
- 35 Onigiri-Inspired Rice with Fully Cooked Egg
- 36 Steamed Sweet Potato with Sesame
- 37 Kabocha Squash Simmered with Ginger
- 38 Soft Udon Soup with Egg and Greens
- 39 Ginger-Soy Braised Daikon and Carrot
- 40 Bok Choy and Mushrooms with Sesame Oil

CHAPTER 05

Fruit, sides, and small comforts

- 41 Cinnamon Apple Compote
- 42 Soft-Cooked Carrots with Olive Oil
- 43 Creamy Rice Pudding
- 44 Plain Yogurt with Stewed Berries
- 45 Savory Oat Cakes
- 46 Brothy Rice with Soft Greens
- 47 Baked Pear with Oats
- 48 Potato and Egg Bowl with Chives
- 49 Soft Prune and Pear Compote
- 50 Warm Ginger Water

Welcome to the table

Food is part of daily life, and the small choices we make in the kitchen can shape how a meal feels. This book gathers 50 warm bowls, simple soups, soft sides, and familiar home-cooked recipes for readers who want more ideas for everyday meals as they age.

Some recipes are inspired by East Asian home cooking. Others use familiar ingredients found in many family kitchens. They are here for their flavor, texture, and practicality. They are not treatments, and no recipe works the same way for everyone.

Digestive symptoms can have many causes. A meal that feels comfortable to one person may bother another. Medicines, health conditions, allergies, dental concerns, swallowing difficulty, and a clinician-prescribed diet can all affect what is appropriate for you. Use this collection as a source of cooking ideas, and ask your doctor, pharmacist, or registered dietitian about food choices that intersect with your care.

How to use this book

Start with the table of contents or the recipe finder. Choose a dish because its ingredients, texture, and preparation suit you today. You do not need to follow the recipe numbers in order, and this book is not a meal plan.

Read the full ingredient list before cooking. Each recipe lists common allergens when known and offers substitutions where practical. A substitution is a cooking suggestion, not a guarantee that it is safe for a particular allergy or medical diet. Check package labels and follow the advice you have received from your care team.

If you are exploring more fiber-rich foods, change one thing at a time and start with a portion that feels comfortable. Fiber needs and tolerance differ. Some people notice more gas with certain fruits, vegetables, legumes, dairy products, or whole grains. Keep notes on foods and symptoms if that is useful, and bring them to a clinician or dietitian rather than removing many foods on your own.

For a recipe that includes ginger, cinnamon, mint, or another herb or spice, the amount is for flavor. It is not a medicinal dose. Do not use concentrated herbal products or supplements based on a recipe in this book. If you take prescription or over-the-counter medicines, ask a doctor or pharmacist before adding an herbal supplement or remedy.

Start with what you notice

This page can help you choose what to discuss with a healthcare professional. It cannot identify the cause of a symptom or tell you which recipe will fix it. If you feel well enough to eat and your clinician has not given you a different plan, browse by flavor, texture, and ingredients you already tolerate.

If bowel movements have become less frequent or harder to pass

Constipation has several possible causes, including medicines, health conditions, changes in routine, activity, fluids, or food. A new or ongoing change is worth discussing with a clinician, especially if it began after a medicine change. Do not stop a medicine or start a laxative or supplement because of a recipe. If you are already advised to add fiber, do so gradually and ask how much is right for you. NIDDK notes that some older adults may not get enough fiber, while personal needs still vary. NIDDK on constipation and nutrition and NIA on constipation in older adults.

If you notice gas or a feeling of fullness

Some gas is normal. Certain foods and drinks bother some people, and not the same foods bother everyone. Beans, lentils, some fruits, dairy, whole grains, and large amounts of fiber can be triggers for some readers. Keep notes about meals and timing rather than removing many foods on your own. Ask a doctor or dietitian if symptoms are frequent, disruptive, changing, or accompanied by pain, constipation, diarrhea, or weight loss. NIDDK on gas and food choices.

If you notice heartburn or food coming back up

People with reflux do not all share the same food triggers. Some common foods are linked with symptoms for some people, but a personal pattern matters more than a universal avoid-list. Discuss symptoms that continue, worsen, or do not improve with your healthcare professional. Chest pain, trouble swallowing, persistent vomiting, bleeding, or unexplained weight loss need medical attention rather than a recipe change. NIDDK on reflux symptoms and food triggers.

If you have diarrhea or repeated vomiting

This book is not a guide to treating diarrhea or vomiting. Older adults can be more vulnerable to complications such as dehydration. Contact a healthcare professional promptly if you cannot keep fluids down, feel confused or faint, have severe pain, see blood or black stool, or symptoms persist or worsen. Follow individualized advice about fluids, medicines, and food. NIDDK on diarrhea and nutrition.

Get help promptly for warning signs

Seek prompt medical care for rectal bleeding or blood in stool, black tarry stool, constant or severe abdominal pain, inability to pass gas with constipation, repeated vomiting, fever with constipation, trouble or pain swallowing, or unexplained weight loss. Chest pain can be an emergency. These examples are not a complete checklist; follow local emergency guidance when symptoms are severe. NIDDK warning signs for constipation and reflux-related warning signs.

A note about traditional food wisdom

Families around the world have used warm broths, rice porridge, cooked fruit, and simple meals as familiar forms of care. Traditions are valuable sources of culinary knowledge, but a traditional use does not prove that a food treats a medical condition. This book names cultural inspirations where known and presents each dish as food.

The East Asian-inspired recipes in this collection are home-cooking interpretations. They are not a complete representation of any cuisine, region, or healing tradition. Ingredients and methods vary across households and communities.

When a recipe book is not enough

Get medical advice for digestive symptoms that persist, keep returning, change suddenly, or interfere with eating and daily life. Do not try to manage a concerning symptom with a recipe first.

Seek prompt medical care for warning signs such as blood in the stool or vomit, black tarry stool, severe or constant abdominal pain, repeated vomiting, inability to pass gas, fever with constipation, difficulty or pain swallowing, or unexplained weight loss. Chest pain may be an emergency. For diarrhea, older adults should seek care promptly when there are signs of dehydration, confusion, frequent vomiting, severe pain, blood or pus in stool, or symptoms that are not improving. Follow local emergency guidance when symptoms are severe.

These warning signs are not a complete checklist. When in doubt, contact a healthcare professional. This book cannot determine what is causing a symptom or whether a particular food is safe for your health situation.

Before you cook

- Follow any meal plan or texture instructions given by your clinician.
- If you have trouble chewing or swallowing, ask your care team which textures are safe. Do not assume a soft food is safe for swallowing difficulty.
- If you have a fluid restriction, kidney or heart condition, diabetes, food allergy, or a prescribed diet, check recipes and portions with your clinician or dietitian.
- Do not stop, reduce, or change a medicine because of a digestive symptom without speaking with the prescriber or pharmacist.
- Wash hands, produce, and kitchen tools; refrigerate perishable leftovers within two hours (within one hour if the temperature is above 90 degrees F / 32 degrees C); and reheat leftovers to 165 degrees F / 74 degrees C. Divide large batches into shallow containers to help them cool promptly.
- Cook eggs until the whites and yolks are firm. Cook egg dishes to 160 degrees F (71 degrees C). Use a food thermometer for meat and poultry; follow current food-safety temperature guidance. Source: FoodSafety.gov safe minimum internal temperatures.

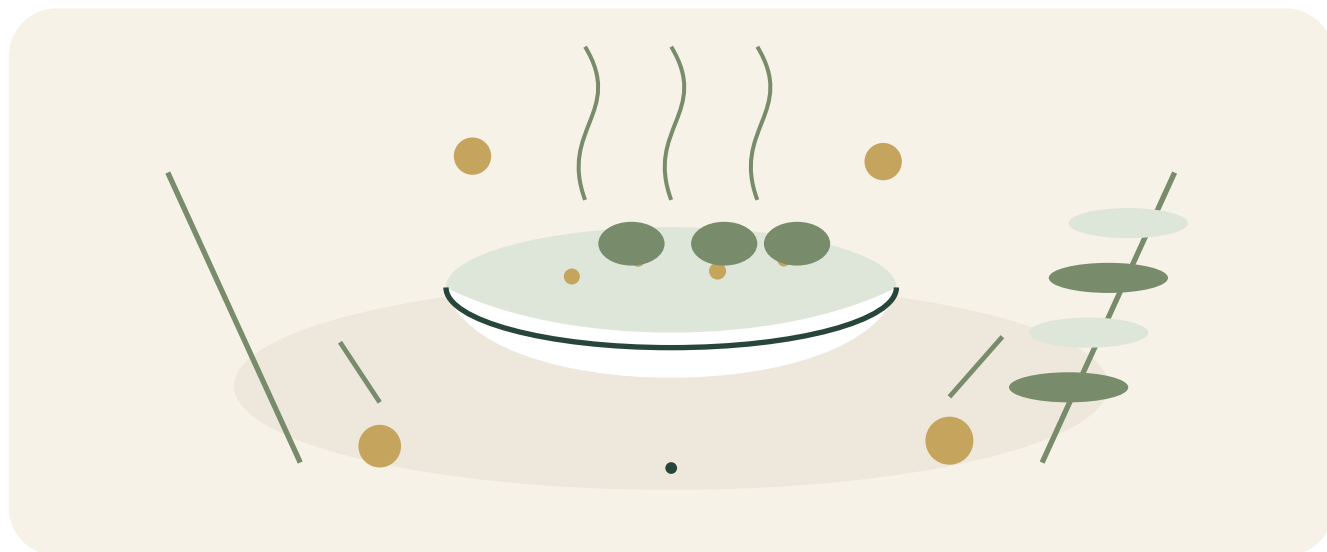
Recipe format

Every recipe will include:

- A short description of flavor, texture, and serving idea.
- Prep time, cook time, yield, and accessible equipment.
- Ingredients in U.S. measures, with metric equivalents where helpful.
- Numbered, plain-language cooking steps.
- A texture or serving note for readers who prefer softer foods.
- Substitutions and allergen reminders.
- A concise "Make it your way" note reminding readers that tolerance varies.

CHAPTER 01

Warm bowls and familiar breakfasts



These ten recipes lean on warm grains, cooked fruit, eggs, fish, and soft textures. Choose them for the flavor and style you enjoy. They are ordinary meal ideas, not symptom treatments or a prescribed plan.

For readers who prefer larger print, the final designed edition will keep recipe steps brief and ingredients clearly separated. A soft texture does not automatically make a food safe for someone with swallowing difficulty; follow the texture guidance from your care team.

RECIPE 01 / CHAPTER 01

Ginger and Scallion Chicken Congee



A slowly simmered rice porridge with tender chicken and fresh scallion. The ginger is optional and included for flavor.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

60-75 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (95 g) white rice, rinsed
- 6 cups (1.4 L) water, or a mix of water and low-sodium chicken broth
- 1 cup (140 g) cooked, plain chicken, finely shredded
- 1 teaspoon finely grated fresh ginger, optional
- 1 scallion, thinly sliced
- 1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil, optional
- Low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional, served at the table

Equipment: Heavy-bottomed pot, spoon, cutting board

MAKE IT

1. Add the rinsed rice and water or broth to a heavy-bottomed pot. Bring to a gentle boil over medium heat.
2. Lower the heat until the liquid barely simmers. Partly cover and cook for 55 to 70 minutes, stirring every 10 to 15 minutes so the rice does not stick. Add a little hot water if the porridge becomes thicker than you like.
3. Stir in the cooked chicken and optional ginger. Simmer for 5 minutes, until the chicken is piping hot.
4. Spoon into bowls. Add scallion and, if desired, a few drops of sesame oil. Let the bowl cool to a comfortable temperature before eating.

TEXTURE

For a smoother porridge, add hot water and stir vigorously, or press some rice against the side of the pot. Remove any tough scallion pieces if preferred.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Leave out ginger, scallion, sesame oil, or soy sauce if they do not suit you. Soy and sesame are major food allergens in the United States; check labels and avoid them if you have been told to do so.

RECIPE 02 / CHAPTER 01

Soft Oatmeal with Stewed Pear



Oats simmer with ripe pear until the fruit softens and the bowl turns creamy.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

10-12 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (80 g) old-fashioned rolled oats
- 2 cups (475 mL) water or milk of choice
- 1 ripe pear, cored and diced small (about 1 cup / 150 g)
- 1/4 teaspoon ground cinnamon, optional
- 1 teaspoon maple syrup, optional
- 2 tablespoons plain yogurt or milk, optional for serving

Equipment: Small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Put oats, water or milk, diced pear, and cinnamon in a small saucepan.
2. Bring to a gentle simmer over medium heat, stirring once or twice. Reduce heat and cook for 7 to 9 minutes, until the oats are soft and pear pieces yield easily to a spoon.
3. Add a splash of water or milk for a looser bowl. Sweeten lightly if desired, then let cool briefly before serving.

TEXTURE

Dice the pear finely for a softer result, or peel it if you prefer. Cook a few minutes longer for very soft fruit.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Pears and oats suit some people and bother others. If they are not a good fit for you, try a fruit or grain you already know you tolerate. Milk, yogurt, and some plant drinks have different ingredients; check labels for allergies and dietary needs.

RECIPE 03 / CHAPTER 01

Savory Oats with Egg and Spinach



A simple savory bowl with creamy oats, wilted spinach, and a fully cooked egg.

PREP
5 minutes

COOK
12 minutes

YIELD
1

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (40 g) old-fashioned rolled oats
- 1 cup (240 mL) water or low-sodium broth
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (15 g) baby spinach, chopped
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 tablespoon grated mild cheese, optional
- Black pepper, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan and skillet, or one saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Bring the water or broth to a gentle simmer. Stir in the oats and cook over low heat for 5 to 7 minutes, stirring until creamy.
2. Meanwhile, warm the oil in a small skillet. Add the spinach and stir for 1 to 2 minutes, until wilted.
3. Cook the egg in the same skillet until the white and yolk are firm, or prepare it another way that cooks it fully.
4. Spoon the oats into a bowl. Top with spinach, egg, and optional cheese or pepper. Cool briefly before eating.

TEXTURE

Chop the spinach finely. Cut the egg into small pieces and stir it through the oats if that is easier to manage.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Oats contain gluten unless specifically labeled gluten-free, and eggs and dairy are common allergens. Use a suitable alternative that fits your own dietary advice.

RECIPE 04 / CHAPTER 01

Millet Porridge with Warm Apple



Millet cooks into a tender, spoonable breakfast with small cubes of soft apple.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

25-30 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (100 g) hulled millet
- 2 cups (475 mL) water
- 1 cup (150 g) peeled, finely diced apple
- 1 cup (240 mL) milk of choice, added near the end
- 1/4 teaspoon cinnamon, optional
- 1 teaspoon honey or maple syrup, optional

Equipment: Fine-mesh strainer, small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Rinse the millet in a fine-mesh strainer under cool running water.
2. Add millet, water, apple, and cinnamon to a saucepan. Bring to a boil, then cover and reduce the heat to low.
3. Simmer for 18 to 22 minutes, stirring once or twice, until the millet is tender and the apple is soft. Add a few tablespoons of water if the pan looks dry before the millet is tender.
4. Stir in the milk and warm gently for 2 to 3 minutes. Add a little more liquid for a softer porridge. Sweeten lightly if desired.

TEXTURE

Millet stays slightly textured. For a smoother result, cook it longer with extra liquid and mash the apple into the grains.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

If millet is unfamiliar or unavailable, use rolled oats and follow the package cooking time. This changes the texture and cooking method.

RECIPE 05 / CHAPTER 01

Steamed Egg Custard with Rice



A tender savory egg custard served with soft rice. This version uses fully cooked eggs and mild seasoning.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

15-20 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180 mL) water or low-sodium broth, warm but not hot
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon finely sliced scallion, optional
- 1 cup (180 g) cooked white rice, kept hot

Equipment: Heatproof bowl, steamer basket with lid, small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Beat the eggs gently in a heatproof bowl. Stir in the warm water or broth and optional soy sauce. Avoid whisking in too much foam.
2. Set the bowl in a steamer basket over gently simmering water. Cover and steam on low for 12 to 16 minutes. The center should be set, not liquid. For a food-safety check, the custard should reach 160 degrees F (71 degrees C) in the center. If needed, steam in 2-minute increments and check again.
3. Remove the bowl carefully; it will be hot. Let stand for 2 minutes. Serve with hot rice and optional scallion.

TEXTURE

For an especially smooth custard, strain the beaten egg mixture through a fine sieve before steaming.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Egg, soy, and sesame-containing sauces can be allergens. Skip any ingredient that conflicts with your care plan. Use low-sodium broth and sauce if sodium intake is a concern, after checking with your clinician.

RECIPE 06 / CHAPTER 01

Salmon and Rice Breakfast Bowl



A warm rice bowl with flaked cooked salmon, soft egg, and a little cucumber for contrast.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

8 minutes, using cooked rice

YIELD

1

YOU WILL NEED

- 3/4 cup (135 g) hot cooked rice
- 2 ounces (55 g) cooked salmon, carefully checked for bones and flaked
- 1 large egg
- 2 tablespoons finely diced cucumber, optional
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon sesame seeds, optional

Equipment: Small skillet or saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Warm the rice until steaming hot. If using refrigerated rice, reheat it to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C), checking in more than one spot if using a microwave. Refrigerate cooked rice within 2 hours in a shallow container and use within 3 to 4 days; discard rice left out longer.
2. Warm the cooked salmon in a skillet over low heat with a teaspoon of water, or add it to the rice while reheating. Heat until steaming hot.
3. Cook the egg until both white and yolk are firm.
4. Place rice in a bowl and top with salmon, egg, and optional cucumber. Add sauce or sesame seeds only if they suit you.

TEXTURE

Flake the salmon carefully and check for bones. Omit the cucumber or chop it very finely for a softer bowl.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Fish, egg, soy, and sesame are common allergens. Use only safely stored, fully cooked fish. If you have a prescribed texture or swallowing plan, follow it.

RECIPE 07 / CHAPTER 01

Silken Tofu and Rice Bowl



Soft tofu and warm rice make a mild bowl that can be seasoned at the table.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

10 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (180 g) cooked white or brown rice
- 7 ounces (200 g) silken tofu, drained
- 1/2 cup (75 g) finely diced zucchini
- 1 teaspoon neutral oil
- 1/4 cup (60 mL) water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon sliced scallion, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan or microwave-safe bowl

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a small saucepan over medium-low heat. Add zucchini and cook for 3 minutes, stirring.
2. Add water or broth, cover, and simmer for 3 to 4 minutes, until zucchini is tender.
3. Add the tofu in large spoonfuls and warm gently for 2 minutes. Avoid vigorous stirring so it keeps some shape.
4. Serve over hot rice. Add optional soy sauce or scallion at the table.

TEXTURE

Break the tofu into smaller pieces and cook the zucchini until it is very tender. For a smoother bowl, stir the tofu into the rice.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Tofu contains soy. Choose white or brown rice according to your preference and any professional dietary advice. Sauces can add sodium, so taste before adding more.

RECIPE 08 / CHAPTER 01

Pumpkin Oatmeal with Cinnamon



Canned pumpkin and oats make a creamy bowl with a familiar autumn flavor.

PREP

3 minutes

COOK

8-10 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (80 g) old-fashioned rolled oats
- 1 3/4 cups (415 mL) water or milk of choice
- 1/2 cup (120 g) plain canned pumpkin puree (not pumpkin pie filling)
- 1/4 teaspoon cinnamon
- 1 tablespoon chopped walnuts, optional
- 1 teaspoon maple syrup, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Stir oats, water or milk, pumpkin, and cinnamon together in a saucepan.
2. Bring to a gentle simmer over medium heat. Reduce heat and cook for 6 to 8 minutes, stirring often, until creamy.
3. Add a splash of liquid if needed. Serve warm with optional walnuts or a small drizzle of maple syrup.

TEXTURE

Leave out the walnuts or chop them very finely. Cook the oatmeal longer with extra liquid for a softer texture.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Check that the can contains plain pumpkin, not sweetened pie filling. Walnuts and milk are common allergens; omit or replace only with foods you know are safe for you.

RECIPE 09 / CHAPTER 01

Soft Polenta with a Fully Cooked Egg



Creamy cornmeal topped with a softly textured but fully cooked egg and a little cheese.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

20-25 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (80 g) quick-cooking or regular polenta/cornmeal; follow package directions
- 2 cups (475 mL) water, plus more as directed on the package
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tablespoons grated Parmesan, optional
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- Black pepper, optional

Equipment: Saucepan and small skillet

MAKE IT

1. Bring the water to a boil in a saucepan. Slowly whisk in the cornmeal, following the package instructions for the amount of liquid and cooking time.
2. Reduce heat and stir often. Add hot water a little at a time if the polenta becomes too thick.
3. In a skillet, cook the eggs until the whites and yolks are firm.
4. Spoon the polenta into bowls. Top with egg, olive oil, and optional Parmesan or pepper.

TEXTURE

Polenta thickens as it stands. Stir in warm water or milk just before serving to loosen it. Cut the egg into small pieces if preferred.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Eggs and dairy are common allergens. Check the package because cornmeal products vary in grind and cooking time. Use a low-sodium cheese or omit it if needed.

RECIPE 10 / CHAPTER 01

Banana Oat Pancakes



Small, tender pancakes made with banana, egg, and oats. Serve plain or with a spoonful of yogurt.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

10-12 minutes

YIELD

6 small pancakes (2 servings)

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 ripe banana
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (40 g) quick oats or rolled oats
- 1/4 teaspoon cinnamon, optional
- 1 teaspoon neutral oil, for the pan
- 2 tablespoons plain yogurt, optional for serving

Equipment: Bowl, fork, nonstick skillet

MAKE IT

1. Mash the banana in a bowl until mostly smooth. Beat in the eggs, then stir in oats and optional cinnamon. Rest for 5 minutes so the oats soften.
2. Warm a nonstick skillet over medium-low heat and lightly coat it with oil.
3. Spoon in batter to make small pancakes. Cook for about 2 minutes, until the edges look set. Flip carefully and cook another 1 to 2 minutes until the center is fully cooked.
4. Serve warm, cut into bite-size pieces if helpful. Add optional yogurt at the table.

TEXTURE

Small pancakes are easier to flip and cook through. Keep the heat moderate so the outside does not brown before the center is done.

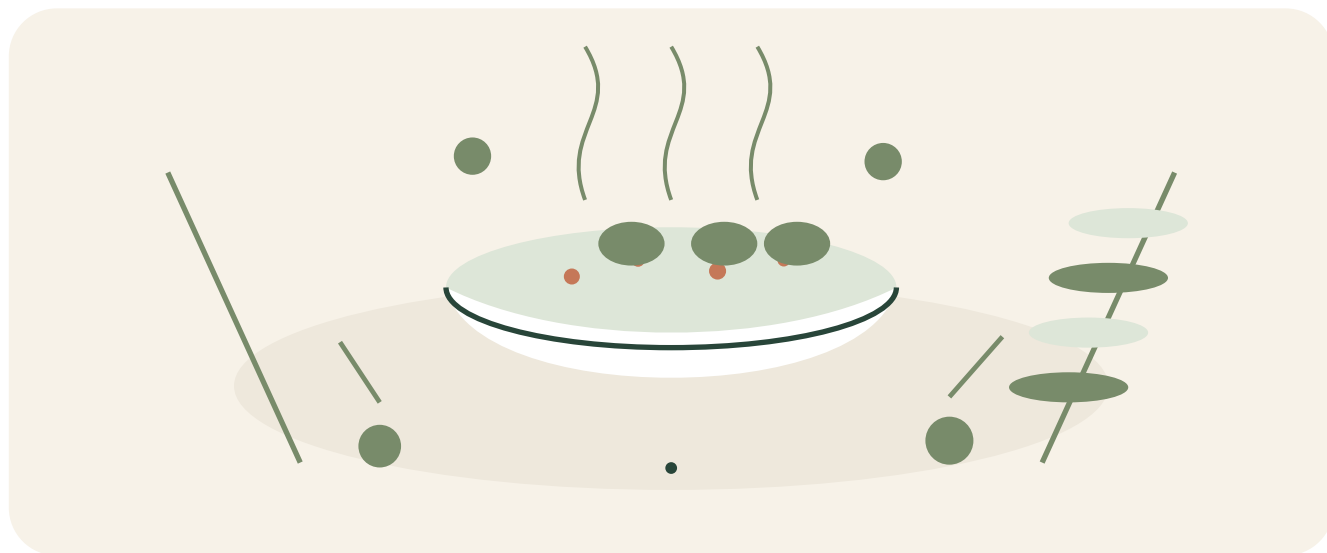
MAKE IT YOUR WAY

This recipe contains egg. Oats may contain gluten through cross-contact unless labeled gluten-free. If using a substitute, choose one that matches your dietary needs.

Chapter one kitchen notes

- Use a stable pot, long-handled spoon, and dry oven mitts. Ask for help with heavy pans or draining boiling water if grip, balance, or vision makes those tasks difficult.
- Refrigerate perishable leftovers within 2 hours (1 hour above 90 degrees F / 32 degrees C), in shallow containers. Reheat leftovers to 165 degrees F / 74 degrees C. Use refrigerated leftovers within 3 to 4 days; freeze sooner if you need longer storage. Source: FoodSafety.gov food-safety steps.
- A texture change can make a dish easier to chew, but it does not establish that the dish is safe for swallowing difficulty. Follow professional guidance.
- Keep a personal note of ingredients that do or do not suit you. One person's experience is not a rule for everyone.

Simple soups and soft suppers



These recipes use familiar vegetables, grains, beans, eggs, fish, and chicken. Most can be made softer by cooking a little longer or chopping ingredients smaller. Season gently, then let each person adjust the bowl at the table.

A note on texture and safety

Soft or blended food is not automatically safe for someone who has difficulty swallowing. Follow any texture plan provided by a clinician or speech-language pathologist. Keep raw meat, poultry, seafood, and eggs separate from ready-to-eat foods, and use a food thermometer where directed.

RECIPE 11 / CHAPTER 02

Carrot and Ginger Soup



Carrots simmer until tender, then blend into a smooth, sunny soup. Ginger is optional and adds a warm flavor.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

25 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 small yellow onion, chopped, optional
- 1 pound (450 g) carrots, peeled and sliced into coins
- 1 teaspoon finely grated fresh ginger, optional
- 4 cups (950 mL) low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- 1/2 cup (120 mL) milk or unsweetened alternative, optional
- Black pepper, optional

Equipment: Large saucepan, blender or immersion blender

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the onion and cook for 4 minutes, stirring, until softened.
2. Add the carrots, optional ginger, and broth or water. Bring to a boil, then reduce the heat, cover, and simmer for about 18 minutes, until the carrots are very tender.
3. Blend carefully until smooth. If using a countertop blender, work in small batches and vent the lid according to the blender instructions.
4. Return the soup to the pot. Stir in optional milk and warm gently. Add water to thin if desired.

TEXTURE

Blend until completely smooth or leave a little texture. Let the soup cool to a safe, comfortable temperature before eating.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Leave out ginger or onion if you prefer a simpler flavor. Check broth labels for sodium and allergens. If you have a prescribed texture or fluid plan, follow that guidance.

RECIPE 12 / CHAPTER 02

Chicken, Rice, and Spinach Soup



A light, familiar soup with tender rice, cooked chicken, and spinach.

PREP
8 minutes

COOK
20 minutes

YIELD
4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 small carrot, peeled and diced small
- 1/3 cup (65 g) white rice, rinsed
- 6 cups (1.4 L) low-sodium chicken broth or water
- 1 1/2 cups (210 g) plain cooked chicken, shredded small
- 1 cup (30 g) baby spinach, chopped
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley, optional

Equipment: Large saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the carrot and cook for 3 minutes.
2. Stir in the rice and broth. Bring to a boil, then cover partly and simmer for 15 to 18 minutes, until the rice is tender.
3. Stir in cooked chicken and spinach. Simmer for 3 to 5 minutes, until the soup is steaming hot and the spinach has softened.
4. Add parsley if desired. Check the temperature before serving and let the soup cool to a comfortable eating temperature.

TEXTURE

Chop the chicken and spinach finely. Add more broth for a thinner soup. If rice thickens the soup as it stands, loosen it with hot water.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Use plain cooked turkey instead of chicken if preferred. Refrigerate leftovers promptly in shallow containers and reheat to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C). Follow your care team's guidance on sodium or fluid intake.

RECIPE 13 / CHAPTER 02

Potato and Leek Soup



Potatoes and carefully cleaned leeks cook into a mellow soup that can be blended smooth or left rustic.

PREP

12 minutes

COOK

25 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 medium leek, white and light-green parts only, sliced and washed well
- 1 pound (450 g) Yukon Gold or other all-purpose potatoes, peeled and diced
- 4 cups (950 mL) low-sodium broth or water
- 1/2 cup (120 mL) milk, optional
- 1 tablespoon chopped chives, optional

Equipment: Large saucepan, blender or potato masher

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the washed leek and cook for 5 minutes, stirring, until softened but not browned.
2. Add potatoes and broth or water. Bring to a boil, then cover and simmer for 18 to 20 minutes, until the potatoes break easily with a fork.
3. Mash the potatoes in the pot for a rustic soup, or blend carefully until smooth. Stir in milk if using and warm gently without boiling.
4. Serve with optional chives.

TEXTURE

Blend for a smooth soup, or mash lightly for soft pieces. Add warm water or broth to thin.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Leeks have a mild onion flavor. Leave them out and add an extra potato if onion-family vegetables do not suit you. Check broth and dairy labels.

RECIPE 14 / CHAPTER 02

Red Lentil and Carrot Soup



Red lentils soften quickly with carrots and a small amount of cumin. The seasoning is easy to leave out.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

25 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (190 g) dry red lentils, rinsed and picked over
- 1 medium carrot, peeled and diced small
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 5 cups (1.2 L) water or low-sodium vegetable broth
- 1/4 teaspoon ground cumin, optional
- 1 tablespoon lemon juice, optional and served at the table

Equipment: Large saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add carrot and cook for 3 minutes.
2. Stir in rinsed lentils, water or broth, and optional cumin. Bring to a boil, then lower the heat and simmer partly covered for 18 to 22 minutes, stirring occasionally.
3. When the lentils are very soft, mash some against the side of the pot to thicken the soup. Add hot water if needed.
4. Serve as is or blend briefly for a smoother texture. Offer optional lemon at the table.

TEXTURE

Red lentils naturally break down as they cook. For a thinner soup, add water a little at a time.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Lentils contain fiber and may not suit everyone. Begin with a portion that fits your own tolerance; do not increase fiber quickly if you have been advised to follow a special diet. Lemon is optional.

RECIPE 15 / CHAPTER 02

Salmon and Potato Chowder



Tender potato and flaky salmon make a simple chowder. The recipe uses milk rather than heavy cream.

PREP

12 minutes

COOK

25 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 small celery stalk, diced small, optional
- 12 ounces (340 g) potatoes, peeled and diced into 1/2-inch (1.25 cm) pieces
- 3 cups (710 mL) low-sodium broth or water
- 12 ounces (340 g) boneless salmon fillet, skin removed
- 1 cup (240 mL) milk or lactose-free milk
- 1 tablespoon chopped dill or parsley, optional

Equipment: Large saucepan, food thermometer

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add optional celery and cook for 3 minutes.
2. Add potatoes and broth. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat and simmer for 12 to 15 minutes, until potatoes are nearly tender.
3. Cut salmon into large pieces and place them gently in the simmering soup. Cover and cook for about 8 minutes, until the fish is opaque and flakes easily. Check the thickest piece with a food thermometer; fish should reach 145 degrees F (63 degrees C).
4. Lower the heat. Stir in milk and warm gently without boiling. Break the salmon into bite-size flakes and add optional herbs.

TEXTURE

Flake the salmon carefully and check for bones. Mash some potatoes into the broth for a thicker chowder or add water to thin.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Fish and milk are common allergens. Use lactose-free milk if suitable, or leave out milk and add broth. Use a separate cutting board for raw fish and wash hands and tools after handling it.

RECIPE 16 / CHAPTER 02

Silken Tofu and Mushroom Soup



Soft tofu, mushrooms, and rice make a mild, spoonable soup. Ginger and soy seasoning are optional.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

18 minutes

YIELD

3

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 teaspoon neutral oil
- 4 ounces (115 g) mushrooms, sliced thin
- 4 cups (950 mL) low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- 1 teaspoon finely grated fresh ginger, optional
- 7 ounces (200 g) silken tofu, cut into small cubes
- 1 cup (180 g) cooked rice
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 tablespoon sliced scallion, optional

Equipment: Medium saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add mushrooms and cook for 4 to 5 minutes, stirring, until softened.
2. Pour in broth or water and add optional ginger. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook for 8 minutes.
3. Add tofu and cooked rice. Simmer gently for 4 minutes, until the tofu is hot throughout and the soup is steaming.
4. Season with optional soy sauce and scallion at the table.

TEXTURE

Cut mushrooms and tofu into small pieces. For a smoother bowl, mash some tofu into the broth. Do not serve very hot.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Tofu and soy sauce contain soy; check labels for allergens and sodium. Mushroom texture is noticeable, so omit mushrooms if you do not enjoy them and add finely diced zucchini instead.

RECIPE 17 / CHAPTER 02

Butternut Squash and White Bean Soup



Squash brings sweetness while white beans make the soup creamy when blended.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

25 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 small carrot, peeled and diced
- 3 cups (450 g) peeled, cubed butternut squash (fresh or thawed frozen)
- 4 cups (950 mL) low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- 1 cup (170 g) canned white beans, rinsed and drained
- 1/4 teaspoon dried thyme, optional
- 1/2 cup (120 mL) water or milk, as needed

Equipment: Large saucepan, blender or immersion blender

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add carrot and cook for 3 minutes.
2. Add squash, broth or water, and optional thyme. Bring to a boil, then cover and simmer for 18 to 22 minutes, until squash is very tender.
3. Stir in rinsed beans and heat for 2 minutes. Blend carefully until smooth, working in batches if using a countertop blender.
4. Thin with water or milk to the texture you prefer. Warm gently before serving.

TEXTURE

Blend thoroughly for a smooth soup, or mash with a potato masher for a thicker, rustic bowl.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Beans contain fiber and may cause gas for some people. Start with a portion that suits your own tolerance or omit the beans and add extra squash. Check canned-food labels for sodium.

RECIPE 18 / CHAPTER 02

Barley, Carrot, and Herb Soup



Pearl barley and vegetables simmer into a hearty soup with parsley added at the end.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

40-45 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (100 g) pearl barley, rinsed
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 medium carrot, peeled and diced small
- 1 small zucchini, diced small
- 6 cups (1.4 L) low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley
- 1 teaspoon lemon juice, optional

Equipment: Large saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add carrot and zucchini and cook for 4 minutes.
2. Add barley and broth or water. Bring to a boil, then cover partly and simmer for 35 to 40 minutes, stirring occasionally, until barley is tender.
3. Add a little hot water if the soup becomes too thick. Stir in parsley and optional lemon juice.
4. Let stand for 5 minutes before serving; barley continues to absorb liquid.

TEXTURE

Barley remains pleasantly chewy. Cook longer with extra water for softer grains. If a smooth or easy-to-swallow texture has been prescribed, ask your care team whether barley is suitable.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Barley contains gluten. For a gluten-free option, use rinsed rice and follow its package cooking time, adding it at the appropriate point so it does not overcook.

RECIPE 19 / CHAPTER 02

Egg-Drop Soup with Soft Greens



A light broth with ribbons of fully cooked egg and finely chopped greens.

PREP
8 minutes

COOK
12 minutes

YIELD
3

YOU WILL NEED

- 4 cups (950 mL) low-sodium chicken or vegetable broth
- 1/2 cup (75 g) finely chopped baby spinach
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 1/2 cup (90 g) cooked rice, optional
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon sliced scallion, optional

Equipment: Medium saucepan, fork or whisk, food thermometer

MAKE IT

1. Bring broth to a gentle simmer in a saucepan. Add spinach and optional rice; cook for 3 minutes.
2. Stir the broth in a slow circle. Gradually pour in the beaten eggs while stirring gently to form thin ribbons.
3. Continue simmering until the egg is fully cooked. For a food-safety check, the soup with egg should reach 160 degrees F (71 degrees C).
4. Add optional soy sauce and scallion. Let the soup cool slightly before serving.

TEXTURE

Chop the greens finely. For a more substantial soup, add rice; for a thinner broth, leave it out.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Eggs, soy, and some broths are allergens. Choose broth to fit your sodium guidance. If you have swallowing difficulty, check with your care team before choosing a soup with mixed textures.

RECIPE 20 / CHAPTER 02

Soft Baked Potato with Yogurt and Chives



A fluffy potato with cool plain yogurt and chives. The microwave shortens the cooking time.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

8-12 minutes in a microwave, or
45-60 minutes in an oven

YIELD

1

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 medium russet or Yukon Gold potato, scrubbed
- 2 tablespoons plain yogurt or sour cream
- 1 teaspoon chopped chives, optional
- 1 teaspoon olive oil, optional
- Black pepper, optional

Equipment: Fork, microwave-safe plate or baking sheet

MAKE IT

1. Pierce the potato several times with a fork. For the microwave, place it on a microwave-safe plate and cook on high for 5 minutes. Turn carefully and continue in 1-minute increments until a knife slides into the center easily.
2. For the oven, heat to 400 degrees F (205 degrees C). Place the pierced potato on a baking sheet and bake for 45 to 60 minutes, until soft in the center.
3. Let stand until cool enough to handle. Split the potato and fluff the inside with a fork.
4. Top with yogurt, optional chives, and olive oil or pepper.

TEXTURE

Scoop the potato from the skin and mash with yogurt for a softer serving. Let steam escape before eating so the center is not too hot.

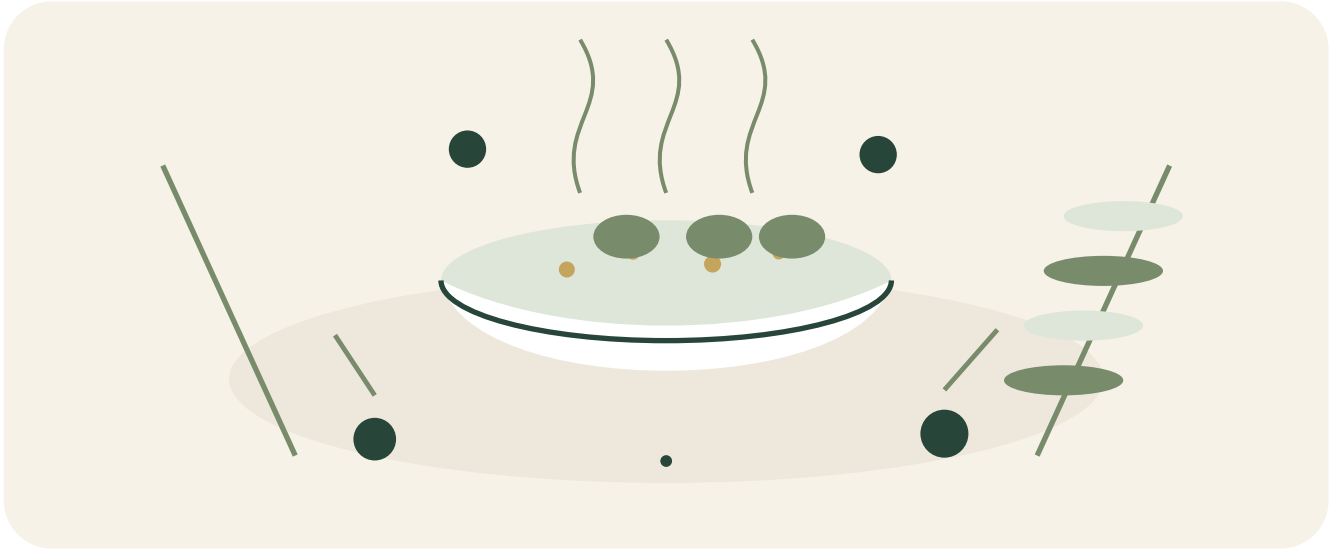
MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Dairy is a common allergen. Choose a suitable alternative only if it fits your dietary needs. Toppings can be kept plain or adjusted at the table.

Chapter two kitchen notes

- Wash leeks carefully between the layers; soil can hide inside them.
- Use a food thermometer to check fish at 145 degrees F (63 degrees C), egg dishes at 160 degrees F (71 degrees C), and reheated leftovers at 165 degrees F (74 degrees C). Refer to [FoodSafety.gov](https://www.foodsafety.gov)'s safe temperature chart.
- Refrigerate perishable leftovers within 2 hours (1 hour above 90 degrees F / 32 degrees C) in shallow containers. Reheat to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C), and use refrigerated leftovers within 3 to 4 days. Refer to [FoodSafety.gov](https://www.foodsafety.gov)'s food-safety steps.
- Broth, soy sauce, canned beans, and miso can add sodium. Choose products according to your preferences and any sodium guidance from your care team.
- If you use a blender, keep the lid vented as directed by its manufacturer and blend hot soup in small batches to prevent splashes.

Plant-forward comfort dishes



These ten recipes bring vegetables, beans, lentils, and whole grains to the table in different forms: a skillet pancake, soft lentils, toast, stuffed vegetables, and grain bowls. Some ingredients contain substantial fiber. Personal tolerance varies, so use the portion that suits you and any guidance from your healthcare professional.

RECIPE 21 / CHAPTER 03

Savory Chickpea Flour Pancakes with Zucchini



Thin, soft pancakes inspired by besan chilla, a savory chickpea-flour preparation enjoyed in parts of South Asia. This simple version uses zucchini and mild seasoning.

PREP

12 minutes, plus 10 minutes to rest

COOK

12 minutes

YIELD

4 small pancakes (2 servings)

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (50 g) chickpea flour
- 1/2 cup (120 mL) water
- 1/2 cup (60 g) finely grated zucchini, squeezed gently to remove excess liquid
- 1 teaspoon olive oil, plus more for the pan
- 1/8 teaspoon ground cumin, optional
- 1 tablespoon chopped cilantro or parsley, optional

Equipment: Mixing bowl, grater, nonstick skillet

MAKE IT

1. Whisk chickpea flour and water in a bowl until smooth. Stir in zucchini, oil, and optional cumin and herbs. Rest for 10 minutes.
2. Warm a nonstick skillet over medium-low heat and brush lightly with oil.
3. Pour about 1/4 cup batter into the pan and spread into a small pancake. Cook for 2 to 3 minutes, until the top looks mostly set and the underside lifts easily.
4. Flip and cook for 2 more minutes. Repeat with remaining batter, adding a little oil as needed.

TEXTURE

Make smaller pancakes so they are easy to turn and cook through. Cook until soft and set, not crisp.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Chickpea flour has a distinct earthy flavor and contains fiber. Start with a portion that fits your tolerance. Check the package for cross-contact if you have a food allergy or need to avoid gluten.

RECIPE 22 / CHAPTER 03

Soft-Cooked Lentils with Carrots and Herbs



Brown or green lentils simmer until tender with carrots, then finish with parsley. Serve on their own or alongside rice.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

30-40 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (190 g) dry brown or green lentils, rinsed and picked over
- 1 medium carrot, peeled and diced small
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 4 cups (950 mL) water or low-sodium vegetable broth
- 1/2 teaspoon dried thyme, optional
- 2 tablespoons chopped parsley
- 1 teaspoon olive oil or lemon juice, optional, to finish

Equipment: Large saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the carrot and cook for 3 minutes.
2. Stir in lentils, water or broth, and optional thyme. Bring to a boil, then lower the heat and simmer partly covered for 25 to 35 minutes.
3. Check a lentil for tenderness. Add hot water and continue simmering in 5-minute increments if needed; cooking time varies by lentil age and variety.
4. Drain excess liquid if necessary. Stir in parsley and optional finishing oil or lemon juice.

TEXTURE

Cook until very tender. Mash a portion with a fork for a softer, thicker dish.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Lentils can increase gas for some people. Try a small portion or choose a different dish if they do not suit you. Follow any clinician-guided diet rather than making a large fiber change on your own.

RECIPE 23 / CHAPTER 03

Brown Rice and Roasted Squash Bowl



Nutty brown rice and soft cubes of roasted squash make a warm bowl with herbs and a spoonful of yogurt.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

35-45 minutes, depending on rice and squash

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (95 g) brown rice, rinsed
- 1 cup (240 mL) water, or amount on rice package
- 2 cups (300 g) peeled butternut squash, cut into 1/2-inch (1.25 cm) cubes
- 1 tablespoon olive oil, divided
- 1/4 teaspoon dried sage or thyme, optional
- 2 tablespoons plain yogurt, optional
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley, optional

Equipment: Saucepan with lid, baking sheet, oven

MAKE IT

1. Heat the oven to 400 degrees F (205 degrees C). Put squash on a baking sheet, toss with half the oil, and spread into one layer.
2. Roast for 25 to 30 minutes, turning once, until very tender and lightly golden.
3. While the squash roasts, cook the rice according to package directions. Let stand covered for 5 minutes, then fluff with a fork.
4. Divide rice between bowls. Top with squash, remaining oil, and optional herbs, yogurt, or parsley.

TEXTURE

Roast squash until a fork passes through easily. For a softer bowl, mash some squash into the rice and add warm water or broth.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Brown rice is a whole grain and may not suit every person or prescribed diet. Use white rice if preferred and follow its package directions. Check yogurt labels for allergens and added ingredients.

RECIPE 24 / CHAPTER 03

Creamy White Beans on Whole-Grain Toast



Mashed white beans turn into a quick savory topping with olive oil and parsley.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

4 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (170 g) canned cannellini or great Northern beans, rinsed and drained
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 2 tablespoons water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon chopped parsley, optional
- 2 slices whole-grain bread
- Black pepper, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan, bowl, fork

MAKE IT

1. Put beans, oil, and water or broth in a small saucepan. Warm over low heat for 3 to 4 minutes, stirring gently.
2. Mash the beans with a fork until creamy, leaving a little texture if you like.
3. Toast the bread to your preferred softness. Spread the beans on top and finish with optional parsley or pepper.

TEXTURE

For a softer serving, use lightly toasted or warmed bread and mash the beans until smooth. If bread is difficult to chew or swallow, follow your care team's texture advice.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Beans and whole grains contain fiber, and both may affect people differently. Try a comfortable serving. Check bread labels for wheat, sesame, and other allergens.

RECIPE 25 / CHAPTER 03

Mashed Sweet Potato with Yogurt-Tahini Swirl



Sweet potato is cooked until tender, mashed with olive oil, and topped with a simple yogurt and tahini swirl.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK10-12 minutes in a microwave, or
35-45 minutes in an oven**YIELD**

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 large sweet potato (about 12 ounces / 340 g), scrubbed
- 2 tablespoons plain yogurt
- 1 teaspoon tahini
- 1 teaspoon warm water, as needed
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- Pinch of cinnamon or cumin, optional

Equipment: Microwave-safe dish or baking sheet, bowl, fork

MAKE IT

1. Pierce the sweet potato several times with a fork. For microwave cooking, place it on a microwave-safe dish and cook on high for 5 minutes. Turn carefully and continue in 1-minute increments until very soft.
2. For oven cooking, heat to 400 degrees F (205 degrees C). Bake on a sheet for 35 to 45 minutes, until a knife slides into the center easily.
3. Let stand until cool enough to handle. Split the potato, scoop the flesh into a bowl, and mash with olive oil.
4. Stir yogurt, tahini, and warm water together until pourable. Drizzle over the potato and add optional seasoning.

TEXTURE

Mash thoroughly and remove any stringy pieces. Add warm water or a little milk to loosen the mash.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Sesame is a major food allergen. Omit tahini if it is not appropriate for you. Dairy is optional; use a suitable alternative only if it fits your dietary needs.

RECIPE 26 / CHAPTER 03

Baked Eggplant with White Beans and Herbs



Soft baked eggplant is paired with warm white beans and parsley for a simple Mediterranean-style plate.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

30-35 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 medium eggplant (about 12 ounces / 340 g), cut into 1/2-inch (1.25 cm) cubes
- 1 tablespoon olive oil, divided
- 1 cup (170 g) canned white beans, rinsed and drained
- 2 tablespoons water or low-sodium broth
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley
- 1 tablespoon plain yogurt, optional
- Black pepper, optional

Equipment: Baking sheet, saucepan, oven

MAKE IT

1. Heat the oven to 400 degrees F (205 degrees C). Toss eggplant with 2 teaspoons oil and spread on a baking sheet.
2. Roast for 25 to 30 minutes, turning once, until soft throughout.
3. Warm beans in a saucepan with water or broth and remaining oil for 3 to 4 minutes. Mash a few beans to make a light sauce.
4. Spoon beans onto plates, add eggplant, and finish with parsley and optional yogurt.

TEXTURE

Roast the eggplant until it collapses easily under a fork. Mash the beans fully for a softer plate.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Beans contain fiber and may not suit everyone. Adjust the portion or leave them out if you have been advised to avoid them. Check broth and yogurt labels.

RECIPE 27 / CHAPTER 03

Chickpea, Rice, and Soft Zucchini Bowl



Soft zucchini and chickpeas are served over rice with a mild parsley dressing.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

12 minutes, using cooked rice

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (180 g) cooked white or brown rice
- 1 cup (165 g) canned chickpeas, rinsed and drained
- 1 small zucchini, diced small
- 1/3 cup (80 mL) water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley
- 1 teaspoon lemon juice, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan with lid

MAKE IT

1. Put zucchini and water or broth in a small saucepan. Cover and simmer for 5 to 7 minutes, until tender.
2. Add chickpeas and oil. Cover and cook for 3 minutes, until hot throughout. Mash some chickpeas with the back of a spoon if you prefer a creamier texture.
3. Warm the cooked rice until steaming hot. If using refrigerated rice, reheat to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C).
4. Spoon rice into bowls and add the zucchini mixture. Finish with parsley and optional lemon juice.

TEXTURE

Dice zucchini small and cook until very soft. Mash or lightly blend the chickpea mixture if a smoother texture is preferred.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Chickpeas are legumes and contain fiber. Start with a portion that feels comfortable. Leave out lemon if acidic flavors do not suit you.

RECIPE 28 / CHAPTER 03

Black Bean and Sweet Potato Mash



Black beans and sweet potato are mashed together with a little olive oil and cumin for a soft, savory dish.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

12-15 minutes, using cooked sweet potato; allow 20-25 minutes if cooking one first

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (200 g) cooked sweet potato, peeled
- 3/4 cup (130 g) canned black beans, rinsed and drained
- 2 tablespoons water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1/8 teaspoon ground cumin, optional
- 1 tablespoon plain yogurt, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan, bowl, fork

MAKE IT

1. If you do not have cooked sweet potato, scrub one, pierce it several times with a fork, and microwave on high for 5 minutes. Turn carefully and continue in 1-minute increments until very soft. Let it stand until cool enough to handle, then remove the skin. (Oven method: bake a pierced potato at 400 degrees F / 205 degrees C for 35 to 45 minutes.)
2. Put sweet potato, beans, water or broth, oil, and optional cumin in a saucepan.
3. Warm over medium-low heat for 6 to 8 minutes, stirring and breaking up the sweet potato.
4. Mash with a fork or potato masher. Add more water a tablespoon at a time until the texture is right for you.
5. Serve warm with optional yogurt.

TEXTURE

Mash thoroughly for a smoother dish. Remove loose bean skins if you prefer a more uniform texture.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Black beans contain fiber and may cause gas for some people. Try a smaller serving or choose a different recipe if beans do not suit you. Dairy is optional.

RECIPE 29 / CHAPTER 03

Quinoa, Spinach, and Egg Bowl



Fluffy quinoa, tender spinach, and a fully cooked egg make a simple savory bowl.

PREP
5 minutes

COOK
20 minutes

YIELD
2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (85 g) quinoa, rinsed
- 1 cup (240 mL) water
- 1 cup (30 g) baby spinach, chopped
- 2 large eggs
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 tablespoon grated Parmesan, optional

Equipment: Fine-mesh strainer, saucepan, skillet

MAKE IT

1. Put rinsed quinoa and water in a saucepan. Bring to a boil, cover, and reduce to low. Simmer for 15 minutes, then remove from heat and let stand covered for 5 minutes.
2. Warm oil in a skillet over medium-low heat. Add spinach and cook for 1 to 2 minutes, until wilted.
3. Cook eggs in the skillet until both whites and yolks are firm. Cut into small pieces.
4. Fluff the quinoa and divide it between bowls. Top with spinach, egg, and optional Parmesan.

TEXTURE

If quinoa's small grains are difficult for you, mix it with soft rice or use a grain whose texture fits your care plan.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Eggs and dairy are common allergens. Check packaged quinoa for handling instructions and rinse it before cooking as directed on the package.

RECIPE 30 / CHAPTER 03

Buckwheat and Mushroom Pilaf



Toasted buckwheat groats simmer with mushrooms and parsley for an earthy, spoonable pilaf.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

20-25 minutes

YIELD

3

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 4 ounces (115 g) mushrooms, chopped small
- 1 cup (170 g) roasted or plain buckwheat groats, rinsed if package directions advise
- 2 cups (475 mL) low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley
- 1 tablespoon plain yogurt, optional

Equipment: Medium saucepan with lid

MAKE IT

1. Warm the oil in a saucepan over medium-low heat. Add mushrooms and cook for 4 minutes, stirring, until softened.
2. Stir in buckwheat and broth or water. Bring to a boil, cover, and reduce the heat to low.
3. Simmer for 12 to 18 minutes, or follow the package timing, until the liquid is absorbed and groats are tender. Add a little hot water if needed.
4. Turn off the heat and let stand covered for 5 minutes. Fluff with a fork and stir in parsley. Serve with optional yogurt.

TEXTURE

Buckwheat groats retain some shape. Cook with extra water for a softer result, checking often near the end.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

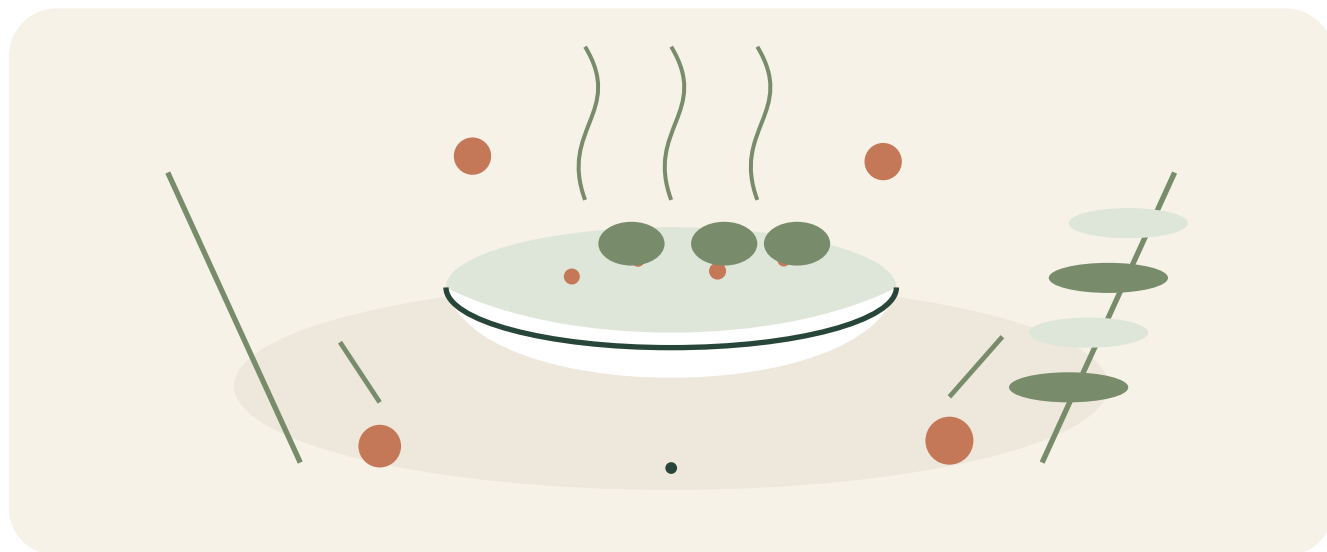
Buckwheat is naturally gluten-free, but cross-contact can happen during processing. If you must avoid gluten, check the package certification. Mushrooms have a distinct texture; chop them finely or leave them out.

Chapter three kitchen notes

- Beans, lentils, chickpea flour, and whole grains are useful ingredients for variety, but tolerance differs. A symptom journal may help you discuss patterns with a clinician or dietitian.
- Canned beans can be rinsed and drained. Follow any sodium or fluid guidance you have received.
- For easier cooking, choose pre-cut squash, microwave a sweet potato, or use frozen vegetables when available.
- Refrigerate cooked grains and leftovers promptly in shallow containers. Reheat leftovers to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C), following FoodSafety.gov's guidance.

CHAPTER 04

East Asian-inspired home cooking



This chapter brings together a handful of home-cooking ideas inspired by different East Asian cuisines. It is not a guide to one region or a complete account of any tradition. Rice porridge, noodles, tofu, greens, and gently cooked vegetables appear in many forms across many households. The recipes here are practical interpretations; ingredients and methods vary by place and family.

Seasonings such as ginger, sesame, soy, and miso are included for flavor, not as remedies. Miso and soy sauce can contain substantial sodium, and personal food triggers differ. Adjust or omit seasonings to fit your needs.

RECIPE 31 / CHAPTER 04

Mushroom and Scallion Rice Porridge



White rice simmers until creamy, then is topped with soft mushrooms and scallion. Leave the toppings plain or season at the table.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

60-70 minutes

YIELD

4

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (95 g) white rice, rinsed
- 6 cups (1.4 L) water or low-sodium vegetable broth
- 4 ounces (115 g) mushrooms, chopped small
- 1 teaspoon neutral oil
- 1 scallion, thinly sliced, optional
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional

Equipment: Heavy-bottomed pot, small skillet

MAKE IT

1. Put rice and water or broth in a heavy-bottomed pot. Bring to a gentle boil.
2. Reduce heat to low so the liquid barely simmers. Partly cover and cook for 55 to 65 minutes, stirring every 10 to 15 minutes. Add hot water if it becomes thicker than you like.
3. While the rice cooks, warm oil in a skillet over medium-low heat. Add mushrooms and cook for 5 to 7 minutes, until very soft.
4. Spoon porridge into bowls and top with mushrooms and optional scallion or soy sauce.

TEXTURE

For a smoother porridge, add hot water and stir well. Chop mushrooms very finely or leave them out.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Soy and mushrooms may not suit everyone. Use water instead of broth for a plainer flavor, especially when monitoring sodium with a clinician.

RECIPE 32 / CHAPTER 04

Tofu and Napa Cabbage Skillet



Napa cabbage softens quickly with tofu in a covered skillet. Serve as a side or spoon over rice.

PREP
8 minutes

COOK
12 minutes

YIELD
2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 teaspoon neutral oil
- 2 cups (150 g) chopped napa cabbage
- 7 ounces (200 g) firm tofu, cut into small cubes
- 1/3 cup (80 mL) water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil, optional
- 1 teaspoon sliced scallion, optional

Equipment: Large skillet with lid

MAKE IT

1. Warm neutral oil in a skillet over medium-low heat. Add cabbage and stir for 2 minutes.
2. Add water or broth and tofu. Cover and cook for 6 to 8 minutes, until cabbage is very tender and tofu is hot throughout.
3. Remove the lid and let extra liquid simmer away for 1 to 2 minutes if desired.
4. Add optional soy sauce, sesame oil, or scallion just before serving.

TEXTURE

Cut tofu into small pieces and cook the cabbage until soft. Mash the tofu lightly into the cabbage for a more uniform texture.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Tofu and soy sauce contain soy; sesame oil contains sesame. Omit any ingredient that conflicts with your allergy or dietary guidance. Cabbage may cause gas for some people.

RECIPE 33 / CHAPTER 04

Sesame Rice Noodles with Tender Vegetables



Soft rice noodles and thinly sliced vegetables are tossed with a light sesame dressing.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

12 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 4 ounces (115 g) dried rice noodles
- 1 small carrot, peeled and cut into thin matchsticks
- 1 cup (70 g) thinly sliced napa cabbage
- 1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon rice vinegar, optional
- 1 tablespoon warm water
- 1 teaspoon sesame seeds, optional

Equipment: Saucepan, colander, small bowl

MAKE IT

1. Cook noodles according to package directions. During the last 2 minutes, add carrot and cabbage to the pot.
2. Drain carefully and rinse briefly with warm water if the package recommends it. Return noodles and vegetables to the pot.
3. Stir sesame oil, optional soy sauce, vinegar, and warm water together. Pour over noodles and toss gently.
4. Serve warm with optional sesame seeds.

TEXTURE

Cut long noodles into shorter lengths with clean kitchen scissors. Cook vegetables until soft, not crisp.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Sesame is a major food allergen; soy sauce contains soy and often wheat. Use a suitable alternative only if it fits your dietary needs. Vinegar is optional.

RECIPE 34 / CHAPTER 04

Mild Miso Vegetable Soup



A simple broth with soft vegetables and a small amount of miso stirred in at the end.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

12 minutes

YIELD

3

YOU WILL NEED

- 4 cups (950 mL) water or low-sodium vegetable broth
- 1/2 cup (75 g) thinly sliced carrot
- 1 cup (70 g) chopped napa cabbage or spinach
- 1/2 cup (75 g) diced soft tofu, optional
- 1 tablespoon white miso to start; add more only to taste
- 1 teaspoon warm water

Equipment: Medium saucepan, small bowl

MAKE IT

1. Bring water or broth to a gentle simmer in a saucepan. Add carrot and cook for 5 minutes.
2. Add cabbage or spinach and optional tofu. Simmer for 3 to 4 minutes, until vegetables are soft and tofu is hot.
3. Put miso in a small bowl. Stir in warm water until smooth, then mix in a ladleful of warm broth.
4. Turn off the heat and stir the thinned miso into the pot. Taste before adding more.

TEXTURE

Chop vegetables finely and cook them until tender. Serve warm rather than piping hot.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Miso can be high in sodium, and tofu contains soy. Use less or leave miso out if it does not fit your needs. Follow clinician guidance for sodium or fluid restrictions.

RECIPE 35 / CHAPTER 04

Onigiri-Inspired Rice with Fully Cooked Egg



Warm rice and a chopped, fully cooked egg make a simple filled rice ball inspired by onigiri. This version is lightly shaped and can also be served loose in a bowl.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

10 minutes, using cooked rice

YIELD

4 small rice balls (2 servings)

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (180 g) hot cooked short-grain white rice
- 1 large egg
- 1 teaspoon neutral oil
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce, optional
- 1 sheet nori, cut into strips, optional

Equipment: Small skillet, bowl, clean damp hands or plastic wrap

MAKE IT

1. Warm the cooked rice until steaming hot. If using refrigerated rice, reheat it to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C).
2. Heat oil in a small skillet over medium-low heat. Beat the egg and cook, stirring gently, until fully set and no liquid egg remains. Chop into small pieces.
3. Let rice cool just enough to handle. Stir egg through rice, or place a little egg in the center of each portion.
4. With clean, damp hands or plastic wrap, shape into four small, loose triangles. Do not compress tightly. Add a nori strip if desired, and eat while warm.

TEXTURE

If shaping feels difficult, serve the rice and egg loose in a bowl. Avoid nori if its chewiness is not comfortable.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Rice and egg are the main ingredients; soy and seaweed are optional. This recipe is not appropriate for someone with swallowing difficulty unless cleared by their care team. Do not leave cooked rice at room temperature; follow the food-safety guidance in this book.

RECIPE 36 / CHAPTER 04

Steamed Sweet Potato with Sesame



Sweet potato is steamed until tender and finished with a small amount of sesame oil or seeds.

PREP
5 minutes

COOK
12-18 minutes

YIELD
2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 medium sweet potato (about 10 ounces / 280 g), peeled and cut into 1-inch (2.5 cm) cubes
- 1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil, optional
- 1 teaspoon sesame seeds, optional
- Pinch of salt, optional

Equipment: Steamer basket with lid, saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Add 1 inch (2.5 cm) of water to a saucepan and set a steamer basket above it. Bring water to a simmer.
2. Place sweet potato in the basket, cover, and steam for 12 to 18 minutes, until very tender when pierced with a fork.
3. Transfer to a bowl and mash lightly or leave in cubes.
4. Add optional sesame oil, seeds, or a small pinch of salt.

TEXTURE

Mash until smooth, adding warm water if needed. Let cool to a comfortable temperature.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Sesame is a major food allergen. Leave it out if needed. If using a microwave steamer, follow the manufacturer's directions.

RECIPE 37 / CHAPTER 04

Kabocha Squash Simmered with Ginger



Kabocha or butternut squash simmers in a lightly seasoned broth until tender enough to cut with a spoon.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

18-22 minutes

YIELD

3

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 pound (450 g) peeled kabocha or butternut squash, cut into 1-inch (2.5 cm) cubes
- 1 cup (240 mL) water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon grated fresh ginger, optional
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon sugar, optional

Equipment: Wide saucepan with lid

MAKE IT

1. Arrange squash in one layer in a wide saucepan. Add water or broth and optional ginger, soy sauce, and sugar.
2. Bring to a gentle simmer. Cover and cook over low heat for 15 to 20 minutes, turning pieces once, until very tender.
3. Remove the lid and simmer for 2 to 3 minutes if you want less liquid in the pan.
4. Serve warm with a spoonful of the cooking liquid.

TEXTURE

Use pre-cut squash if cutting hard squash is difficult. Simmer until a fork passes through easily; mash for a softer serving.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Ginger and soy sauce are optional. Choose broth and seasoning to fit any sodium guidance you have received.

RECIPE 38 / CHAPTER 04

Soft Udon Soup with Egg and Greens



Udon noodles simmer in a mild broth with greens and a fully cooked egg stirred in at the end.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

12 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 4 ounces (115 g) dried udon or 1 package precooked udon, prepared as directed
- 4 cups (950 mL) low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- 1 cup (30 g) chopped spinach or napa cabbage
- 1 large egg, beaten
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce, optional
- 1 teaspoon sliced scallion, optional

Equipment: Medium saucepan, food thermometer

MAKE IT

1. Prepare noodles according to package directions. Drain if the package instructs.
2. Bring broth or water to a gentle simmer. Add greens and cook for 3 minutes.
3. Add noodles and heat until steaming. Stir the soup slowly while pouring in the beaten egg in a thin stream.
4. Continue cooking until egg is fully set and the soup with egg reaches 160 degrees F (71 degrees C). Add optional soy sauce or scallion.

TEXTURE

Cut noodles into shorter lengths with clean scissors. Cook greens until soft. If mixed textures are difficult, check with your care team before choosing this soup.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Udon is usually made with wheat; check package labels. Eggs, soy, and broth ingredients can be allergens. Choose sodium levels with your clinician's advice.

RECIPE 39 / CHAPTER 04

Ginger-Soy Braised Daikon and Carrot



Daikon and carrot slowly soften in a small amount of broth with ginger. Serve as a side or over rice.

PREP

10 minutes

COOK

25 minutes

YIELD

3

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 medium daikon radish (about 12 ounces / 340 g), peeled and cut into 1/2-inch (1.25 cm) half-moons
- 1 medium carrot, peeled and cut into thin coins
- 1 cup (240 mL) water or low-sodium broth
- 1 teaspoon grated fresh ginger, optional
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, optional
- 1 teaspoon neutral oil

Equipment: Lidded saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Put daikon, carrot, water or broth, ginger, and oil in a saucepan. Bring to a gentle boil.
2. Reduce heat, cover, and simmer for 18 to 22 minutes, turning vegetables once, until easily pierced with a fork.
3. Remove the lid. Add optional soy sauce and simmer for 2 minutes.
4. Serve warm with a spoonful of the cooking liquid.

TEXTURE

Cut vegetables into smaller pieces and cook longer for a softer result. Mash with a fork if you prefer.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Daikon has a mild peppery flavor. Use extra carrot if it is unavailable. Ginger and soy are optional; soy sauce can add sodium.

Bok Choy and Mushrooms with Sesame Oil



Bok choy and mushrooms steam-sauté in a covered skillet until tender, then get a few drops of sesame oil.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

10 minutes

YIELD

2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 teaspoon neutral oil
- 4 ounces (115 g) mushrooms, sliced thin
- 2 small bok choy (about 8 ounces / 225 g), washed and sliced crosswise
- 1/4 cup (60 mL) water
- 1/2 teaspoon toasted sesame oil, optional
- 1 teaspoon low-sodium soy sauce, optional

Equipment: Large skillet with lid

MAKE IT

1. Warm neutral oil in a skillet over medium-low heat. Add mushrooms and cook for 4 minutes, stirring.
2. Add bok choy and water. Cover and cook for 4 to 5 minutes, until the stems and leaves are soft.
3. Remove the lid and let extra liquid simmer away. Turn off the heat.
4. Add optional sesame oil or soy sauce and toss gently.

TEXTURE

Slice stems thinly and cook until soft. Chop the cooked vegetables into smaller pieces before serving if helpful.

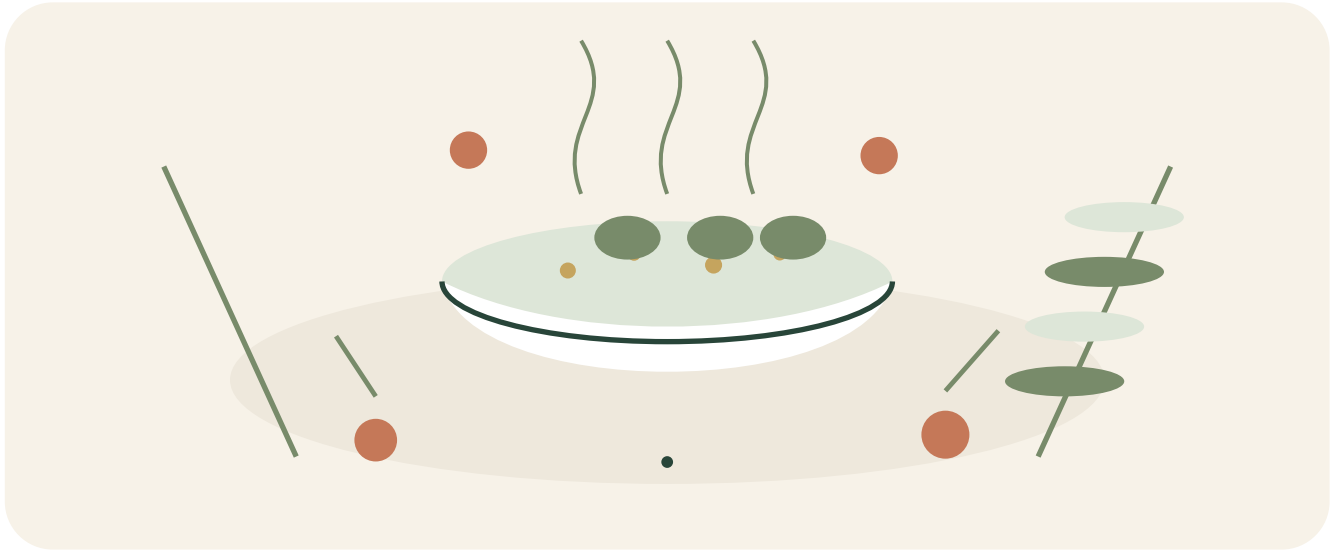
MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Sesame is a major food allergen and soy sauce may contain soy and wheat. Omit or replace only with a product you know is suitable for you.

Chapter four kitchen notes

- "East Asian-inspired" describes a range of influences, not one uniform cuisine. These are home-cooking interpretations; names, seasonings, and methods vary across regions and households.
- Miso, soy sauce, broth, and prepared noodles can contain sodium. Check labels and follow personal medical guidance.
- Cooked rice needs careful handling. Refrigerate perishable leftovers promptly in shallow containers and reheat to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C); see [FoodSafety.gov](https://www.foodsafety.gov)'s guidance.
- Sesame and soy are common allergens. Read labels on packaged sauces and noodles.
- If swallowing is difficult, shaped rice, noodles, seaweed, and mixed-texture soups need individual professional guidance.

Fruit, sides, and small comforts



These final recipes are simple additions to a meal or small plates for quieter moments: cooked fruit, vegetables, yogurt, rice, and oats. They are included for their familiar ingredients and flexible textures. They are not remedies, and they will not suit every person or every medical diet.

RECIPE 41 / CHAPTER 05

Cinnamon Apple Compote



Apples simmer with water and cinnamon until spoon-soft. Serve warm, chilled, or alongside oatmeal.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

15 minutes

YIELD

About 2 cups (4 small servings)

YOU WILL NEED

- 3 medium apples, peeled, cored, and diced small
- 1/3 cup (80 mL) water
- 1/4 teaspoon ground cinnamon, optional
- 1 teaspoon maple syrup, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Put apples and water in a saucepan. Cover and bring to a gentle simmer over medium-low heat.
2. Cook for 10 to 12 minutes, stirring once or twice, until apples are very tender.
3. Mash with a fork for a chunky compote or stir until smoother. Add cinnamon and optional maple syrup.
4. Cool before storing or serving.

TEXTURE

Peel the apples and cook them until they collapse easily. Mash well for a softer spoonful.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Apples may not suit everyone. Use a fruit you already enjoy if preferred. Sweetener is optional.

RECIPE 42 / CHAPTER 05

Soft-Cooked Carrots with Olive Oil



Carrot coins steam-simmer until tender, then are tossed with olive oil and parsley.

PREP
5 minutes

COOK
12-15 minutes

YIELD
3

YOU WILL NEED

- 3 medium carrots, peeled and sliced into 1/4-inch (6 mm) coins
- 1/3 cup (80 mL) water
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 tablespoon chopped parsley, optional
- Pinch of salt, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan with lid

MAKE IT

1. Put carrots and water in a saucepan. Cover and bring to a simmer.
2. Cook over low heat for 10 to 13 minutes, checking with a fork. Add a little water if the pan dries before carrots are tender.
3. Drain any remaining water. Toss carrots with olive oil and optional parsley.
4. Let cool to a comfortable temperature before serving.

TEXTURE

Cook a few minutes longer for very soft carrots. Mash with a fork if that texture is more comfortable.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Use less oil or omit salt to fit your own preferences and any clinical guidance.

RECIPE 43 / CHAPTER 05

Creamy Rice Pudding



Rice slowly simmers with milk until soft and creamy. Cinnamon is optional.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

35-40 minutes

YIELD

4 small portions

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (95 g) uncooked short- or medium-grain white rice, rinsed
- 4 cups (950 mL) milk or lactose-free milk
- 1 cup (240 mL) water
- 1 tablespoon sugar, optional
- 1/4 teaspoon cinnamon or 1 teaspoon vanilla, optional

Equipment: Heavy-bottomed saucepan, spoon

MAKE IT

1. Combine rice, milk, and water in a heavy-bottomed saucepan. Bring to a gentle simmer over medium heat, stirring often.
2. Reduce heat to low. Cook uncovered for 30 to 35 minutes, stirring frequently, until rice is very soft and mixture is creamy.
3. Stir in optional sugar and cinnamon or vanilla. Add a splash of milk if you prefer a looser pudding.
4. Serve warm or chill promptly in shallow containers for later.

TEXTURE

Rice pudding thickens as it cools. Stir in milk before serving to loosen it. Serve at a comfortable temperature.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Milk is a common allergen and may not suit everyone. Choose a suitable alternative only if it fits your dietary advice; cooking time and creaminess may change.

RECIPE 44 / CHAPTER 05

Plain Yogurt with Stewed Berries



Warm berries spooned over plain yogurt make a simple snack or dessert.

PREP
3 minutes

COOK
5 minutes

YIELD
2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (150 g) fresh or frozen blueberries or raspberries
- 1 tablespoon water
- 1 teaspoon honey or maple syrup, optional
- 1 cup (240 g) plain yogurt
- 1 tablespoon finely chopped walnuts, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Put berries and water in a saucepan. Warm over low heat for 4 to 5 minutes, stirring until berries soften and release some juice.
2. Mash a few berries with a fork. Stir in optional honey or maple syrup.
3. Divide yogurt between two bowls and spoon warm berries on top.
4. Add optional walnuts just before serving.

TEXTURE

Mash berries thoroughly and leave out nuts for a smoother snack. Let the fruit cool slightly before adding it to yogurt.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Yogurt, milk, and walnuts are common allergens. Berries and dairy may not suit everyone. Use plain yogurt that fits your needs and check package labels.

RECIPE 45 / CHAPTER 05

Savory Oat Cakes



Small skillet cakes made with oats, egg, and a little cheese. Serve warm with soup or vegetables.

PREP

8 minutes

COOK

10 minutes

YIELD

4 small cakes (2 servings)

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (80 g) quick oats
- 1 large egg
- 1/3 cup (80 mL) milk or water
- 2 tablespoons grated cheddar or Parmesan, optional
- 1 teaspoon olive oil, for the pan
- 1 tablespoon finely chopped chives, optional

Equipment: Bowl, fork, nonstick skillet

MAKE IT

1. Stir oats, egg, milk or water, optional cheese, and chives together. Let stand for 5 minutes.
2. Warm oil in a nonstick skillet over medium-low heat.
3. Spoon batter into four small rounds. Cook for 3 to 4 minutes, until edges look set and the underside is golden.
4. Turn carefully and cook another 3 to 4 minutes, until the cakes are fully cooked through. For a food-safety check, the center should reach 160 degrees F (71 degrees C). If needed, continue cooking over low heat and check again.

TEXTURE

Make thin cakes and cook over low heat so the centers set before the outsides become crisp. Break into small pieces before serving.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Oats may contain gluten through cross-contact unless labeled gluten-free. Egg and dairy are common allergens. Use water instead of milk if suitable.

RECIPE 46 / CHAPTER 05

Brothy Rice with Soft Greens



Cooked rice warms in broth with spinach until it becomes a quick, spoonable bowl.

PREP
5 minutes

COOK
10 minutes

YIELD
2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 cup (180 g) cooked white rice
- 3 cups (710 mL) low-sodium broth or water
- 1 cup (30 g) chopped baby spinach
- 1 teaspoon olive oil, optional
- 1 teaspoon grated ginger, optional
- 1 tablespoon chopped scallion, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Bring broth or water to a simmer in a saucepan. Stir in cooked rice and optional ginger. If using refrigerated rice, reheat the finished bowl to 165 degrees F (74 degrees C).
2. Simmer for 5 minutes, stirring once or twice, until rice is hot and soft.
3. Add spinach and cook for 2 to 3 minutes, until wilted and tender.
4. Serve warm with optional olive oil or scallion.

TEXTURE

Add more broth for a thinner bowl or simmer longer for a thicker one. Chop greens finely.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Broth can contain sodium. Rice and spinach suit some people and not others. Add seasoning only if it fits your preferences and clinician guidance.

RECIPE 47 / CHAPTER 05

Baked Pear with Oats



A ripe pear bakes under a light oat topping until both fruit and topping are tender.

PREP
8 minutes

COOK
25-30 minutes

YIELD
2

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 large ripe pear, halved and cored
- 2 tablespoons rolled oats
- 1 teaspoon butter or olive oil
- 1 teaspoon maple syrup, optional
- Pinch of cinnamon, optional
- 2 tablespoons water for the baking dish

Equipment: Small baking dish, oven

MAKE IT

1. Heat oven to 375 degrees F (190 degrees C). Place pear halves cut-side up in a small baking dish and add water to the dish.
2. Mix oats with butter or oil, optional syrup, and cinnamon. Spoon the mixture over the cut sides.
3. Cover loosely with foil and bake for 20 minutes. Uncover and bake for 5 to 10 minutes, until pear is soft when pierced with a fork.
4. Cool before serving. Spoon any pan juices over the pear.

TEXTURE

Peel the pear and bake until very soft. Mash the fruit and oats together if preferred.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Pears and oats may not suit everyone. Leave out the sweetener if the fruit is ripe enough for your taste.

RECIPE 48 / CHAPTER 05

Potato and Egg Bowl with Chives



Soft potato and a fully cooked egg make a simple warm bowl with chives.

PREP

5 minutes

COOK

15-20 minutes

YIELD

1

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 medium Yukon Gold or red potato, peeled and cut into 1/2-inch (1.25 cm) cubes
- 1 large egg
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 tablespoon plain yogurt, optional
- 1 teaspoon chopped chives, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan, fork

MAKE IT

1. Put potato in a saucepan and cover with water. Bring to a boil, then simmer for 10 to 12 minutes, until very tender.
2. Meanwhile, place egg in a small saucepan and cover with water. Bring to a boil, then turn off heat, cover, and let stand for 12 minutes. Transfer egg to cool water, peel, and chop. The yolk and white should be firm.
3. Drain potato and mash lightly with olive oil and optional yogurt.
4. Fold in chopped egg and chives. Serve warm, not hot.

TEXTURE

Mash the potato fully and chop the egg small. Add warm water or milk to loosen the bowl.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Egg and dairy are common allergens. Skip yogurt or use an alternative that fits your diet. If you have texture or swallowing instructions, follow your care team's advice.

RECIPE 49 / CHAPTER 05

Soft Prune and Pear Compote



Dried prunes and pear simmer into a soft fruit compote. This recipe is included as a food preparation, not a laxative or constipation treatment.

PREP
8 minutes

COOK
15-18 minutes

YIELD
About 2 cups (4 small servings)

YOU WILL NEED

- 1/2 cup (85 g) pitted dried prunes, roughly chopped
- 1 ripe pear, peeled, cored, and diced small
- 1 cup (240 mL) water
- 1 small strip lemon zest, optional
- Pinch of cinnamon, optional

Equipment: Small saucepan

MAKE IT

1. Put prunes, pear, and water in a saucepan. Bring to a gentle simmer over medium-low heat.
2. Cover and cook for 12 to 15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until fruit is very soft.
3. Remove the lemon zest if used. Mash with a fork or blend briefly for a smoother compote.
4. Cool before serving. Refrigerate leftovers promptly in a covered container.

TEXTURE

Blend until smooth or mash well. Serve a small spoonful alongside another food rather than assuming a larger serving is right for everyone.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Prunes and pears contain natural sugars and may not suit everyone. Start with a small amount if you are unfamiliar with them. This recipe does not replace medical advice or prescribed care.

RECIPE 50 / CHAPTER 05

Warm Ginger Water



A simple, lightly flavored drink made by steeping fresh ginger in hot water. It is included for flavor and warmth only.

PREP
3 minutes

COOK
-

YIELD
1 cup

YOU WILL NEED

- 1 thin slice fresh ginger (about 1/8 inch / 3 mm), optional
- 1 cup (240 mL) freshly boiled water
- Small strip lemon peel, optional

Equipment: Kettle or small saucepan, mug, fine strainer

MAKE IT

1. Put ginger and optional lemon peel in a heat-safe mug.
2. Pour in hot water and steep for 5 to 7 minutes.
3. Remove the ginger and peel. Let the drink cool to a comfortable temperature before sipping.

TEXTURE

Strain carefully and remove all pieces before serving. Do not serve scalding-hot drinks.

MAKE IT YOUR WAY

Ginger and citrus do not suit everyone. Omit either ingredient if it conflicts with your preferences or medical guidance. This drink is not a treatment or a substitute for fluids recommended by a clinician.

Chapter five kitchen notes

- Cooked fruit and warm drinks are included for taste and texture; this book does not assign them a medical effect.
- Refrigerate yogurt, cooked rice, pudding, and fruit promptly in shallow containers. Follow food-safety recommendations in the front matter.
- Keep portions flexible and follow any dietary, sodium, sugar, or fluid guidance from your care team.

Practical pages for The Root and Bowl

These pages are optional tools for choosing and preparing recipes. They are not a meal plan, medical advice, or a way to diagnose food intolerance. Use them alongside any instructions from your healthcare team.

1. Find a recipe by the kind of meal you want

Choose by taste, texture, time, and ingredients you already know work for you. Recipe numbers refer to the main book.

I want a warm, spoonable meal

- Rice porridge: 1, 31
- Oatmeal or millet: 2, 3, 4, 8
- Soups: 11-19, 34, 38
- Brothy rice: 46

I want a soft-cooked vegetable or fruit

- Carrots: 11, 12, 14, 18, 39, 42
- Squash: 17, 23, 37
- Cooked fruit: 2, 41, 47, 49
- Soft greens: 3, 12, 29, 32, 34, 38, 46

I want a plant-forward dish

- Lentils, beans, or chickpeas: 14, 17, 22, 24, 26, 27, 28
- Quinoa, barley, or buckwheat: 18, 29, 30
- Vegetables with rice: 27, 32, 39, 40

I want a short preparation

- About 15 minutes or less, not counting pre-cooked rice or advance preparation: 3, 7, 24, 27, 32, 33, 34, 40, 42, 44, 45, 46, 48, 50.
- Check each recipe's timing and equipment. Rice, grains, and some fruit preparations take longer than the hands-on time suggests.

I prefer a mild flavor

Try a plain version of recipes 2, 3, 5, 7, 12, 13, 20, 23, or 43. Leave out optional ginger, citrus, herbs, sauces, or spices that you already know do not suit you. "Mild" is a flavor description, not a guarantee that a dish is right for a medical condition.

2. Seven flexible meal pairings

Use these as examples of how recipes can be combined. They are not complete nutrition plans and do not set calories, nutrients, portions, or a schedule. Add or change foods to meet your needs and any advice from your clinician or registered dietitian. Skip any ingredient that is not suitable for you.

Day	First meal idea	Midday idea	Evening idea	Optional small plate
1	#2 Soft Oatmeal with Stewed Pear	#12 Chicken, Rice, and Spinach Soup	#20 Soft Baked Potato with Yogurt and Chives	#44 Yogurt with Stewed Berries
2	#8 Pumpkin Oatmeal	#24 Creamy White Beans on Toast	#23 Brown Rice and Roasted Squash Bowl	#41 Cinnamon Apple Compote
3	#5 Steamed Egg Custard with Rice	#16 Silken Tofu and Mushroom Soup	#15 Salmon and Potato Chowder	#42 Soft-Cooked Carrots
4	#4 Millet Porridge with Warm Apple	#26 Baked Eggplant with White Beans	#38 Soft Udon Soup with Egg and Greens	#43 Creamy Rice Pudding
5	#3 Savory Oats with Egg and Spinach	#14 Red Lentil and Carrot Soup	#39 Ginger-Soy Braised Daikon and Carrot over rice	#47 Baked Pear with Oats
6	#10 Banana Oat Pancakes	#33 Sesame Rice Noodles with Tender Vegetables	#29 Quinoa, Spinach, and Egg Bowl	#44 Yogurt with Stewed Berries
7	#1 Ginger and Scallion Chicken Congee	#25 Mashed Sweet Potato with Yogurt-Tahini Swirl	#32 Tofu and Napa Cabbage Skillet with rice	#49 Soft Prune and Pear Compote

3. Shopping checklist

This is a flexible starter list, not a complete list for every recipe. Pick recipes first, then use their ingredient lists to choose quantities. Package sizes and household needs vary.

Produce

- ☐ Apples and pears
- ☐ Bananas and berries, fresh or frozen
- ☐ Carrots
- ☐ Potatoes and sweet potatoes
- ☐ Squash, fresh or frozen
- ☐ Zucchini and mushrooms
- ☐ Spinach, napa cabbage, or bok choy
- ☐ Leek, onion, scallion, chives, parsley, or cilantro
- ☐ Ginger, lemon, or lemon peel (optional)

Grains and pantry foods

- ☐ White rice and/or brown rice
- ☐ Rolled oats and/or millet
- ☐ Quinoa, pearl barley, buckwheat, or noodles for selected recipes
- ☐ Red, brown, or green lentils
- ☐ Canned white beans, chickpeas, and black beans
- ☐ Chickpea flour
- ☐ Dried prunes
- ☐ Low-sodium broth, or ingredients for water-based versions

☐ Cinnamon, cumin, thyme, or sage (optional)

☐ Low-sodium soy sauce or tamari, miso, sesame oil, or rice vinegar for recipes that use them

Refrigerated foods and proteins

☐ Eggs

☐ Plain yogurt or lactose-free yogurt

☐ Milk or a suitable alternative

☐ Tofu

☐ Salmon or plain cooked chicken for selected recipes

☐ Cheese, tahini, or walnuts only if suitable for your household

Before checkout

☐ Read labels for allergens, sodium, added sugar, and ingredients you need to avoid.

☐ Choose package sizes for the specific recipes you plan to make.

☐ Ask for help carrying or opening items if needed.

☐ Keep chilled foods cold on the trip home and refrigerate them promptly.

4. Ingredient and texture substitutions

These are cooking ideas, not medical substitutions. A swap changes flavor, texture, and sometimes nutrition. For allergies, prescribed diets, kidney or heart conditions, diabetes, swallowing difficulty, or fluid limits, confirm choices with your clinician or dietitian.

If a recipe calls for	You could consider	What changes
Fresh spinach	Chopped frozen spinach, thawed and drained	More moisture; cook briefly and adjust liquid
Butternut squash	Kabocha or another squash you can safely prepare	Sweetness and cooking time vary
Brown rice	White rice	Softer texture and different cooking time; follow package directions
Milk	Lactose-free milk or a suitable plant beverage	Flavor, protein, and thickness vary; check labels
Fresh parsley	Chives or cilantro, or omit	Flavor changes; herbs are optional in most recipes
Canned beans	Another canned bean	Texture and flavor change; rinse and drain if desired
Fresh ginger	Omit it	The dish will taste milder; no replacement is required
Soy sauce	Omit it or use a product that meets your needs	Sodium and allergen content vary; check the label

Do not replace ingredients one-for-one when a recipe depends on their structure, such as egg in a pancake or rice in a rice ball, without testing the recipe first.

5. Food and comfort journal

Bring this page to an appointment if you want help discussing patterns. Record observations without assuming that a food caused a symptom. A clinician or dietitian can help interpret them.

Date and time	Food and drink	What I noticed and when	Other context or questions
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Questions I may want to ask

- Could any of my medicines or supplements be affecting digestion?
- Are any of these ingredients unsuitable with my health conditions or prescribed diet?
- Is it appropriate for me to change my fiber intake or fluid intake?
- Do I need a particular texture because of chewing or swallowing concerns?
- What symptoms mean I should seek care promptly?

6. Medicine and supplement conversation card

Take an up-to-date list to your appointment or pharmacy. Include prescription medicines, over-the-counter medicines, vitamins, herbal products, teas or concentrated extracts used as supplements, and how often you take them. Do not stop or change a medicine based on this worksheet.

Name of medicine or product	Amount and how often	Why I take it / who recommended it	Question for my clinician or pharmacist
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Before trying a supplement or herbal remedy

- Ask a doctor or pharmacist whether it could interact with your medicines or health conditions.
- Bring the actual package or a clear photo of its ingredient list.
- Do not assume that "natural" means safe or that a food recipe and a concentrated supplement are equivalent.
- Follow professional advice about medicines, supplements, diet, and fluid intake.

Sources and further reading

The safety guidance in this book is informed by public resources from the National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases and the National Institute on Aging. These organizations explain that digestive symptoms can have different causes, that food triggers vary, that older adults may have medication-related risks, and that some symptoms call for medical attention. The recipe collection remains general food education and should be reviewed by a registered dietitian or qualified clinician before publication.

Selected references

- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. Definition and Facts for Constipation
- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. Symptoms and Causes of Constipation
- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. Eating, Diet, and Nutrition for Constipation
- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. Eating, Diet, and Nutrition for Gas
- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. Eating, Diet, and Nutrition for GER and GERD
- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. Eating, Diet, and Nutrition for Diarrhea
- National Institute on Aging. Constipation
- National Institute on Aging. Taking Medicines Safely as You Age
- FoodSafety.gov. 4 Steps to Food Safety
- FoodSafety.gov. Safe Minimum Internal Temperatures